told, for our own safety. A lump of coral may appear to be flashing a deep blue smile at you, but that smile belongs to a clam that can snap off an unwary finger.

South of Vijaynagar is the other sunrise beach, Kala Pathar, named for the dark rocks on the shore. This part of the island is a popular morning excursion with guests at Tilar Siro. Armed with a light breakfast and binoculars, we trek through the forest, immersed in the dark majesty of towering semoa and Andaman ash. The wet grey clay slips under our feet, and we wade through small streams. Vines hang down, a bronze-back tree snake slips silently over a branch, and the only sounds are the occasional deep "roo" of a wood pigeon. Suddenly the air lightens and we hear the sea. The view is broad here, at what they call the Secret Beach. Hermit crabs stumble across each other, leaving their tiny tracks everywhere. Sometimes you can see dolphins, my guide tells me. Just as he says it, I am positive I see one dark head bobbing far away. He gazes through his binoculars for a while, but it turns out to be a black rubber float that has detached itself from a fisherman's net.

At the busier main entrance to Kala Pathar, there are beach chairs and changing booths. Stalls line the road, selling shell art and 'coral' strings dyed an implausible red. None of it has sullied the peaceful atmosphere. Families play in the water, and when the sun gets hot, they can retreat into the cool forest. The forest trek here is gentler, on level ground, and stays close to the sound of waves.

Sunset at the Radhanagar Beach, at the southwest part of the island, is an entirely different experience again. Tourists swarm the approach road, speaking every single language and feasting on cut fruit and snacks from a row of shacks. Past the picnic tables, the view suddenly opens to an elegant curve of white sand. Swimmers are safer in the middle, but if you're wading or walking, the horns of the curve are the most rewarding. On the southern end, sand bubblers texture the beach with precise radial patterns. These are created by their unique habit of ingesting sand, filter-feeding on the nutrients in it, and ejecting perfect little spheres.

PLANET PERFECT

The resort follows the CGH Earth principles of sustainability and harmony with the environment



Getting There: From the Veer Savarkar airport at Port Blair, it is a 10-minute taxi ride to the Phoenix Bay Ferry. Ferries run in the morning and afternoon to Swaraj Dweep, and it's best to firm up your ferry booking well in advance. The ferry ride takes under two hours to reach Swaraj Dweep. From the Swaraj Dweep jetty, it is a 10-minute ride to the Tilar Siro resort.

The Stay: Room rates vary seasonally, and the resort has garden rooms with balcony (Rs 22,795-26,525 exclusive of taxes for double occupancy, breakfast included), sea-facing rooms with balcony (Rs 26,525-30,255), and sea-facing pool villas (Rs 41,950-60,595). Apart from the breakfast buffet and live counter, guests are encouraged to order their meals in advance, as the kitchen uses low-intensity cooking methods. Candlelight dinners with wine can be arranged on the lawn with a view of the beach, at prices ranging from Rs 7,500 to 15,000 plus taxes.

The resort has its own guide for birdwatching, treks and intertidal walks, and nature activities can be organised for children. A variety of scuba diving, snorkelling and kayaking activities are on offer from Lacadives, which has its office in the same compound as the resort.

See cghearth.com for more information.

